Physical Research Laboratory, Ahmedabad had spotted it as a suitable location as it was very close to the earth's magnetic equator. This was the quiet beginning of modern rocket-based research in India. The site selected at Thumba lay between the railway line and the sea coast, covering a distance of about two and a half km and measuring about 600 acres. Within this area, stood a large church, whose site had to be acquired. Land acquisition from private parties is always a difficult and time-consuming process, especial y in densely populated places like Kerala. In addition, there was the delicate matter of acquiring a site of religious significance. The Col ector of Trivandrum then, K Madhavan Nair, executed this task in a most tactful, peaceful and expeditious manner, with the blessings and cooperation of Right Rev. Dr Dereira, who was the Bishop of Trivandrum in 1962. Soon RD John, the executive engineer of the Central Public Works Department (CPWD), had transformed the entire area. The St. Mary Magdalene church housed the first office of the Thumba Space Centre. The prayer room was my first laboratory, the Bishop's room was my design and drawing office. To this day, the church is maintained in its ful glory and, at present,